

YPRES 2026: PARENT BRIEFING MEETING • TEACHER RUNNING SHEET

Mr Ben Lovett (Head of History) • Meeting Duration: ~30 mins + Q&A

Tour Dates: 1–3 Oct 2026 • Handout Follow–Along Order

1. WELCOME & OPENING HOOK: CONNECTING VILLAGE STREETS TO FLANDERS

00:00 – 05:00

The Teacher's Core Hook: *"This is not a passive holiday. Our pupils are traveling as field historians to honour young men from our own village who once walked the very streets our students walk today."*

Pte Thomas John Franklin (Age 23 • 1st Hampshires) **MENIN GATE • PANEL 35**
Lived at Meadow Cottage, Chark, Lee-on-the-Solent. Killed 29 April 1915 defending Frezenberg Ridge under gas & intense shelling. No known grave.

Pte Sydney Muckett (Age 21 • 15th 'Pompey Pals') **TYNE COT • PANELS 88–90**
Lived at Brown's Farm, Stubbington; Grocer's errand boy. Killed 20 Sept 1917 during Menin Road Ridge assault (Passchendaele). No known grave.

Pte William (Walter) Ayling (Age 20 • 1st Hampshires) **MENIN GATE • PANEL 35**
Lived in Stubbington Lane; village Baker Boy. Killed by shellfire north of Ypres 9 July 1915. Commemorated side-by-side with Pte Franklin.

Pte Arthur Rye (Age 21 • 14th 'Pompey Pals') **TYNE COT • PANELS 88–90**
Lived at Lower Crabthorne, Hill Head; Nurseryman. Brother-in-law to Muckett family; killed in Polygon Wood 6 days after Sydney (26 Sept 1917).

2. EXPEDITION ITINERARY (FOLLOWS HANDOUT PAGE 1)

05:00 – 12:00

- ▶ **Joint Venture & Care:** Led by Mr Ben Lovett & Mr James Garrett (The History Boys) + 2 Meoncross staff. High **1:8 staff ratio**, private executive coach throughout.
- ▶ **Day 1 (Thu 1 Oct):** Meet **06:15** at Meoncross (**06:30 sharp** departure). Eurotunnel Le Shuttle. Afternoon: Essex Farm ADS (John McCrae 'In Flanders Fields' & 15–yr-old Pte Strudwick), Langemarck German Cemetery (somber contrast), Hooge Crater trenches. Check-in Peace Village Hostel; 18:15 dinner & debrief.
- ▶ **Day 2 (Fri 2 Oct):** Vancouver Corner (gas attacks); Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62 preserved deep trenches); supervised supermarket lunch at Aldi in Ypres; Tyne Cot (locating village fallen); Lijssenthoek CCS (Nurse Nellie Spindler); Passchendaele 1917 Museum (20ft underground dugout); **20:00 Menin Gate Last Post Ceremony** (Meoncross wreath laying & Panel 35 tribute).
- ▶ **Day 3 (Sat 3 Oct):** Daylight Menin Gate & Ramparts; De Groote artisan chocolate shop in Ypres; Talbot House in Poperinge ('Every Man's Club'); Town Hall death cells; 14:30 departure; ~20:00 arrival back at Meoncross.
- ▶ **Digital App Callout:** Direct parents to the QR code on the handout: live updates, itinerary, poems, and maps at [meoncross-history.netlify.app](#).

3. LOGISTICS, MANDATORY KIT & ACCOMMODATION (FOLLOWS HANDOUT PAGE 2)

12:00 – 22:00

⚠ **Sanctuary Wood Footwear (CRUCIAL):** Preserved frontline trenches have real, deep mud. Mandatory **separate pair of wellies/walking boots + clean change of trainers + strong plastic bag** to seal muddy boots before re-boarding coach!

- ▶ **Warm Clothing:** Waterproof hooded coat, warm fleece/layers. **Warm hat & gloves mandatory**—standing still on stone ramparts at Menin Gate at 8 PM is freezing!
- ▶ **MANDATORY TOWELS:** Pupils **MUST bring their own bath/shower towels**. The hostel does not provide towels for school groups.
- ▶ **Luggage:** 1 main holdall (max 15kg, coach hold) + 1 small daypack (inside coach with waterproofs, boots bag, packed lunch, water).
- ▶ **Toiletries:** Roll-on deodorant only. **Strictly NO aerosols** (triggers coach/fire alarms).

- ▶ **Food & Catering:** Day 1 packed lunch from home for coach. Days 2 & 3 supervised Belgian supermarket lunch stops (fresh rolls, fruit). Buffet breakfasts & 2-course evening dinners included at hostel.
- ▶ **Spending Money:** **€30 to €40 in cash (Euros)** for supermarket lunches and chocolate gifts.
- ▶ **Passports & GHIC:** Collect tonight (valid UK passports >3 months validity + GHIC/EHIC cards). European 2-pin adapter for charging phones.
- ▶ **Mobile Phone Policy:** Allowed by day for photos and app. **Collected every night in staff phone bag at curfew** to ensure proper rest.
- ▶ **Accommodation & FAQ:** Peace Village Hostel, **Nieuwkerkestraat 9aB, 8957 Mesen** (+32 57 226 040). Mention website FAQ link ([peacevillage.be/en/practical/faq](#)).
- ▶ **Rooming & Dietaries:** Friend pairing forms and dietary requirements (e.g. vegetarian evening meals) in ~2 weeks.

4. IMMEDIATE PARENT ACTIONS & DEADLINES

22:00 – 25:00

1. Code of Conduct: Signed agreement by pupil & parent returned by **Fri 25 Sept**.

2. Passports & GHIC: Hand in to Mr Lovett tonight (or School Office this week).

3. Emergency Contact: 24/7 School Base +44 (0)1329 662182.

5. CONCLUDING WORDS TO PARENTS & OPEN Q&A (25:00 – 30:00)

"When your sons and daughters return to Meoncross on Saturday evening, they will be tired, and their boots will have the Flanders mud on them. But they will also return with an enduring sense of perspective, having stood where our village boys stood and carried their memory forward. Thank you for entrusting them to us."

👉 *"I'd now be delighted to open the floor to any questions you or your children may have."*